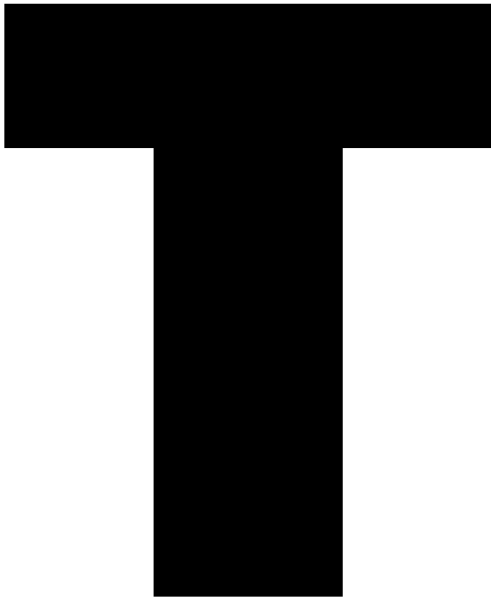




THE MUCH-AWAITED *BT*-PwC India's Best CEOs ranking for this year has winners from diverse fields. It reflects the challenging phase India Inc. has faced, with increasing geopolitical tensions being one of the most prominent risks. This underscores the need for companies to have robust business models that can withstand the shocks.

What is clear from conversations with these industry captains is that they place equal emphasis on growth strategy and the need to be agile to face any unexpected event. That event could be a policy change, or a war, or trade-related issues, or even extreme weather events. This is a time when India Inc. is clearly intertwined in the glob-

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al economy and every decision has ramifications greater than what it was, say, a decade or two ago. Of course, it helps to operate from a country that has remained resilient unlike so many others, and provides a plethora of opportunities to those quick enough to spot them.

Another aspect that becomes clear is the CEOs' ability to keep their eyes fixed firmly on their goals. When the funds were gushing in, it might have been easy to make a big-ticket acquisition. At that point, liquidity may not have seemed much of a problem. But just a couple of dramatic changes in the business environment can unravel that strategy. This is an oft-repeated story that underlines the importance of a long-term outlook. For, it is a truth universally acknowledged that blips for a quarter or two seldom make a difference to a good firm. The skill of those who head them lies in picking the trends—local and global—and working to convert them to opportunities.

This year's list of best CEOs reflects that trend. It has stories of resilience, smart conservatism, doggedness and an insatiable appetite for success. The takeaway is clear: Success stems from the ability to think long term, regardless of what prevails in the present.

In the following pages we bring you these stories of leaders who have steered their firms, and the country, through the tough times. **BT**

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